

STUDY SHEET

Before the face of God

Torah: Leviticus 16:1–34 · **Haftarah:** Isaiah 57:14–58:14 · **Gospel:** Matthew 25:31–46

Yom Kippur begins not with our experience but with God's holiness: Aaron draws near in God's way, receives atonement first for himself, and the guilt is carried away — “before the LORD you shall be clean.” Isaiah 58 unmasks a fast that stays mere form, and Matthew 25 tests the fruit: whoever truly lives from atonement cannot let the least become invisible. Hebrews 9–10 points to Yeshua, the High Priest who by His own blood appears “in the presence of God for us.”

§0 Observation round

0.1 Blind observation

Leviticus 16 opens after the death of Nadab and Abihu (16:1): drawing near to God is not self-evident. Aaron may not enter at any moment, and must first make atonement for himself (16:6,11) before he can draw near for the people. Not only people but the sanctuary too is cleansed (16:16): sin touches the holy space. Two goats (16:8–10): one for the LORD, one for Azazel, led away bearing the confessed guilt (16:21–22) — sin is named and carried away. The whole is “once a year” (16:34), and the heart: “before the LORD you shall be clean” (16:30). Ending: affliction and sabbath rest (16:29–31). Isaiah 58 unmasks a fast that stays form and hides injustice; Matthew 25 separates sheep and goats on the treatment of the least.

0.2 The four axes as an open question

Does the weight fall on what God is and does (Source: holiness, atonement as God's work), on the wholeness of inner and outer (Coherence: received atonement ↔ treatment of the neighbour), on the response (Will: humbling, resting, receiving), or on the movement through time (Trajectory: the feasts, and fulfilment in Yeshua)?

0.3 The centre of gravity read off

● Load-bearing are **Source** and **Coherence**: God is holy and gives the atonement (Aaron draws near in God's way; cleansing "before His face"), and that received atonement becomes visible in how we treat the least (Isa. 58 / Matt. 25). Centre of gravity: standing before the face of God — and whoever has been there cannot let the other become invisible.

0.4 Framing test

● Guarded. The weekly reflex lands on "receiving"; here that is grounded (atonement is God's work, 16:30), but text and constellation push on to Coherence (inner ↔ outer). Two guards: (1) the turn to the neighbour must not become works-righteousness — fruit shows the root, is not the root (Matt. 25 does not reverse Lev. 16); (2) the Hebrews layer must not flatten Leviticus 16 into one-to-one typology: the pattern points, it does not settle the account.

§1 The thread

Atonement begins with God's holiness, not with our experience; we receive access, we do not grasp it. Guilt is not only named but carried away — and whoever receives that God sees him and carries his guilt away begins to see the other and stops holding on to another's guilt.

§2 Peshat per block

Block	What it says (peshat)	Keyword / contrast	Open question
Lev. 16:1–5	After Nadab/Abihu: not entering at any moment; Aaron draws near with offerings.	drawing near · holiness	Why does the day begin with God's holiness, not with us?
16:6–14	First atonement for the priest and his house; blood on/before the mercy seat.	first for himself	Why does the high priest draw near as a dependent?
16:15–19	The sanctuary too is cleansed of Israel's uncleannesses.	sanctuary cleansed	How does sin touch the shared space?

16:20– 22	Hands on the live goat, confession, led away to Azazel in the wilderness.	naming ↔ carrying away	What does “carried away” mean for confessed guilt?
16:23– 28	Cleansing, burnt offerings; the one who led the goat washes himself.	cleansing · outside the camp	Why does even the sending touch uncleanness?
16:29– 34	Affliction, no work, sabbath rest; “clean before the LORD”; once a year.	affliction + rest	How do affliction and rest go together?
Isa. 57:14– 58:14	A fast that stays form vs. the fast God chooses: justice, bread, clothing the naked; justice and sabbath.	form ↔ justice	Where does form become a hiding place?
Matt. 25:31– 46	Sheep/goats separated on the treatment of the least = of Yeshua himself.	the least · surprise	What does the fruit show about the root?

§3 Two load-bearing axes

Axis	Text anchors	Diagnosis	Open anomaly
Source	16:2 (holiness) · 16:16,30 (God cleanses) · Heb. 9:12,24	Load-bearing. God is holy and gives the atonement; becoming clean happens “before His face,” not at a distance.	Why is nearness possible only along this way?
	16:16 (sanctuary) · Isa. 58:3–7 · Matt. 25:40	Load-bearing, second pole. Inner (atoned heart) and outer (treatment of the least) belong together; form cut off from life hides injustice.	Where does “seeing the other” become a new proof of achievement?
Will	16:29–31 (afflict/rest) · Isa. 58:6	Response, not source: humble, rest, receive — not to be the blood or the way yourself.	Where does affliction become a project?
Trajectory	Teruah → Shuvah → Kippur · Heb.	Serving. The feasts run out on this day; Hebrews points to the	Pointer or own core?

§4 Sources round

Van de Giessen does not cover Leviticus (does cover Genesis 1–25 and Deut. 18–34); the witnesses were verified via Sefaria.

●/● **Azazel (16:8) — four lines.** (a) Peshat/translation: “the goat that goes away / is sent away” — so the LXX read it (apopompaios), and so “scapegoat” (KJV) ●; this carries the “carried away” motif. (b) Place: a hard, steep mountain/cliff (Yoma; Saadiah Gaon: a mountain name) ●. (c) Wilderness power: Ibn Ezra hides a “secret” (“when you are 33 you will know it”); Ramban decodes it as a demonic power — with the emphatic guard that the goat is not an offering to that power, but is sent at God’s command to its domain, while the atonement is made “before the LORD” ●. (d) Aggada: Uzza/Azael, the fallen “sons of God” (Yoma 67b) ●.

● **Chok (Yoma 67b / Lev. 18:4).** The sent-away goat stands among the statutes that “the satan” and the nations mock as irrational; “I am the LORD, I decreed it.” Discipline note: the rite is a decree, not a rationalisable mechanism — red against over-explanation.

● **“Before the face” (16:30; Yoma).** “lifnei HaShem tit’haru” — becoming clean happens before Him; in the Temple service priests and people fell down at hearing the pronounced Name. Anchors the day’s title.

● **Hebrews 9–10 (confessional).** Yeshua enters the true sanctuary once by His own blood and appears “in the presence of God for us” (9:12,24). Horizon, not flat typology: the pattern (priest, blood, access, atonement) points; it does not settle the peshat of Leviticus 16.

● **Onkelos on 16:8 (Azazel as a place?):** still to be verified.

Revision gate. Did the round shift the centre? Confirming and sharpening: the peshat “sent away” carries Source/carrying-away; the chok note guards against over-explaining; and “before the face” anchors the centre — without letting the reflex become flat surrender.

§5 Direction test as horizon

● Confessional. Matthew 25 tests the fruit of received atonement: whoever has truly stood before God's face cannot let the hungry, the stranger and the prisoner become invisible — “what you did for the least, you did for Me.” And Hebrews 9–10 confesses Yeshua as the High Priest who opened the way. ● Guarded: Matt. 25 and Heb. 9–10 do not settle the peshat of Leviticus 16; both are horizon. And the turn to the neighbour is fruit, not price — Lev. 16 stands: the atonement comes first from God.

§6 Status table

Claim	Status
Drawing near is not self-evident; atonement is God's work; clean “before His face” (16:2,30)	● load-bearing
Guilt named and carried away (two goats, 16:21–22); the sanctuary itself cleansed (16:16)	● load-bearing
Received atonement visible in treatment of the least (Isa. 58 / Matt. 25:40)	● load-bearing
Azazel as “sent-away goat” (LXX/peshat)	● peshat
Azazel as mountain / wilderness power (Yoma; Ibn Ezra/Ramban) and Uzza/Azael (Yoma 67b)	● suggestive (rabbinic/aggada)
The goat as chok — decree, not a rationalisable mechanism (Lev. 18:4)	● load-bearing (discipline)
Reflex-landing on flat “receiving”; “seeing the other” as proof of achievement	● guardrail
Yeshua as High Priest “in the presence of God for us” (Heb. 9–10)	● confessional
Onkelos on 16:8	● open verification point

§7 Podcast rendering

One physical image: the people watching the goat leave — further and further, until it is out of sight. What has been confessed you need not keep nursing as though holding on shows more reverence; God carries it away. And the second half: whoever has received like that comes outside and suddenly sees the person he first walked past.

§8 Source accountability

Azazel lines (LXX/peshat; Yoma 67b; Ibn Ezra and Ramban on 16:8; Saadiah) and the chok note (Lev. 18:4) — verified via Sefaria. “Before the face” (16:30) and the Temple service — Yoma. Hebrews 9–10 confessional (●). Van de Giessen not available for Leviticus. Onkelos: still to be verified. Name: Yeshua. Author: Arie Alberts.